

DOODLE vs the best clothing websites in the world

Gap analysis and build plan · 5 July 2026 · 10-agent research pass: 5 benchmark researchers (SKIMS, Jacquemus, Aime Leon Dore, Uniqlo, The Souled Store, Snitch, Mini Rodini, Stoney Clover Lane, Hopscotch, FirstCry, plus Baymard Institute and WebAIM research) and 5 auditors over the live site and both repos.

Verdict: 4.2 / 10 overall. The engineering discipline is above the bar for this stage (security, consent, structured data, motion system). What holds the site back is not code, it is proof: there is no real photograph anywhere, the founders are bracketed placeholders, three testimonials are invented, and every date on the live site is in the past. A visitor in July 2026 reading "First drop May 2026" next to "[Founder One]" concludes the company is dead. The good news: roughly half of the severity-5 findings are one-file content edits.

Scorecard

DIMENSION	SCORE	WORLD-CLASS BAR (WHAT THE BEST ACTUALLY DO)	DOODLE TODAY
Design & brand	4.5	Photography carries ~90% of identity; UI is recessive monochrome; one campaign world per season; 6-8 folds, one job each (SKIMS is ~3,700px and 6 sections).	Real design-system rigor and a sharp voice, but zero real photography (AI renders only), 12 folds with three consecutive "lots of patches" sections, a fabricated ₹1499 strikethrough, and placeholder people.
Commerce funnel	4.0	Baymard-complete PDP (age-mapped sizes, fabric, care, returns beside the buy button), 5-8 image gallery, shipping step with real rate and ETA, pincode-checked COD, cross-sell everywhere attach rate lives.	Strong bones (server actions, IDOR fixed, stock states, India-native payments) but the live PDP hides the size guide, checkout has no shipping-method step, COD is offered blind, one photo and no gallery, and a post-purchase CTA that 404s.
Content & trust	3.0	Named founders with faces, only real attributable proof, FAQ answering the category's actual objections, cm size chart, WhatsApp channel, complete transactional email set.	Legal backbone above startup grade and real transactional emails, but fabricated testimonials live in production, anonymous founders, no FAQ, no size chart, no WhatsApp, shipped/delivered emails built but never wired.
Technical	6.0	Pass all three Core Web Vitals (The Souled Store fails all three; Myntra and FirstCry fail two), complete structured data, WCAG AA, sub-300KB OG images so WhatsApp previews work.	The strongest dimension: CSP, HSTS, DPDP-serious consent, honest JSON-LD. Held back by a 2.1MB OG image that kills WhatsApp link previews, a canonical bug pointing most pages at the homepage, an infinite soft-404 space on /shop/*, and an all-client homepage bundle.

Mobile & features	3.5	Mobile-first everything (75%+ of Indian D2C traffic), full mobile menu, sticky add-to-cart, mini-cart with cross-sell, 44px targets, referral loop on the waitlist.	Tap-based configurator and a genuinely good checkout form, but no mobile menu at all below 1024px, sub-44px cart controls, no add-to-cart feedback beyond a text whisper, and no referral mechanic. Enterprise noise (search, wishlist, loyalty) correctly skipped.
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The ten most damaging gaps, ranked

#	GAP	SEV	EFFORT	WHY IT MATTERS
1	Stale dates everywhere: "First drop May 2026", pop-ups from January, all in the past	5	S	A drop brand with expired dates reads as abandoned. Fatal for a waitlist ask.
2	Placeholder people live in production: [Sneha], [Ravi], [Anjali] testimonials, [Founder One/Two/Three], [hello@example.in]	5	S	Fabricated proof discovered by one mom in a WhatsApp group ends the brand. Also an ASCI risk.
3	No real photography: every visual is an AI/3D render, zero kids in tees	5	L	Kidswear is bought on the image of a real child in the garment. Renders say "concept", photos say "product".
4	Checkout has no shipping-method step (Medusa cart.complete can hard-fail)	5	M	Blocks the production flip outright; orders may fail at "Place order" or ship with no fulfillment option.
5	Live PDP has no size guide, fabric, care, or trust info (it exists but only renders in the fallback branch)	5	S	Sizing doubt is the #1 abandonment and returns driver in kidswear. The component is already written.
6	No mobile menu below 1024px	4	M	Three quarters of traffic cannot reach "How it works" or "Patch library" from the header.
7	Razorpay completion trusts the client: no signature verification before cart.complete	4	M	An unpaid browser can mint an order; a paid one that closes the tab gets charged with no order.
8	COD offered blind, no pincode serviceability check	4	M	Unchecked COD in India runs 20-30% RTO. Lethal at pre-seed unit economics.
9	No WhatsApp presence anywhere	4	S	WhatsApp is the default commerce channel for this exact audience. A wa.me link costs nothing.
10	2.1MB square JPEG as OG image and favicon	4	S	WhatsApp silently drops link previews above ~300KB, so every shared link shows as a bare URL. Sharing is the free growth channel.

Also confirmed at severity 4: contradictory numbers ("200+ patches" vs the real 40, "6 base colours" vs 2 swatches, unexplained "₹370"), dead-end Shop CTAs in waitlist mode, the fabricated ₹1499 anchor, the /account/claim 404, PDP single-photo gallery, unwired shipped/delivered emails, no FAQ, no real size chart, dead footer links plus a TikTok icon (banned in India since 2020), and licensed-brand name-drops (Avengers, Pokemon, Iron Man) in homepage copy despite the existential IP rule.

What the best sites taught us (the bar, compressed)

- **Photography is the product.** On SKIMS and Jacquemus all colour lives in the images; UI is monochrome and tiny. DOODLE's inversion (colourful illustrated UI, no photos) is exactly backwards for fashion.
- **Commit to one density model.** Editorial-tight (SKIMS, 6 sections) or merch-dense (Souled Store, 14,600px). A pre-commerce brand cannot credibly fill a dense page, so run tight: 6-8 folds, one job each.
- **Named drops as franchises.** The Souled Store's engine is banner-templated named drops; Mini Rodini does it with owned characters. DOODLE's five packs are five drops waiting for a calendar.
- **Stoney Clover Lane is the proven patch-commerce playbook:** cheap repeatable units, a live preview with an honest disclaimer, save/share, and public sellouts. The ₹100 silicone singles are DOODLE's version of their letter patches.
- **Kidswear trust is component-level:** height-in-cm sizes with age equivalents next to the buttons, wash-tested claims with numbers, small-parts safety answered before it is asked. 82% of apparel sites under-inform on sizing, so doing this well is cheap differentiation.
- **India checkout is its own standard:** pincode-first autofill, UPI-first ordering, visible COD with a nudge to prepaid (5% discount is the observed norm), 15-day exchange as the category floor.
- **Performance is a winnable moat, not table stakes:** verified field data shows The Souled Store fails all three Core Web Vitals and Myntra/FirstCry fail two. A lean Next.js site that passes all three beats every reference competitor on measurable UX.
- **The trust voice for an unknown brand is The Whole Truth's:** expose one uncomfortable truth (what a ₹999 tee costs to make, or the no-licensed-characters stance as a promise), publish proof, write like a person.

The plan

Phase 0: credibility triage

TODAY, ~1 DAY OF EDITS

Almost entirely one file (src/content/home.ts). Kill everything that makes the site look dead or dishonest.

- Fix or remove every stale date; switch the drop banner to undated scarcity ("First drop · 200 tees · Bangalore").
- Unrender EarlyVoices (invented testimonials) and FindUsOffline (past pop-ups) until real content exists.
- Founders section: real five names (Ronit, Lakshay, Ash, Rohit, Aditya) with one true line each; photos when available.
- Delete the fake ₹1499 strikethrough; fix "200+" to the derived real patch count; reconcile "6 colours" vs 2 swatches; explain or drop "₹370".
- Rewrite the two Promise pillars to drop Avengers/Pokemon/Iron Man trademarks (generic "superhero phase" language keeps the insight).
- Fix the stockist placeholder email, dead footer links, dead anchors; remove TikTok.
- Waitlist-mode CTAs: nav "Shop the drop" becomes "Join the first drop"; BuildYourTee "Add this kit" becomes "Reserve this kit" scrolling to the waitlist form.

Phase 1: mobile and trust basics

THIS WEEK, CODE, ₹0

- Mobile hamburger menu (full-screen sheet: nav links, waitlist CTA, WhatsApp, socials).
- /faq page (wash durability, velcro feel, small-parts safety, sizing, drop logistics, returns) with FAQPage JSON-LD; /size-guide with the real cm table from the production spec sheet.
- wa.me click-to-chat in footer, contact page, and mobile menu.
- Branded 404 page (the patch characters exist for exactly this), 1200x630 OG image under 300KB plus a proper favicon set, canonical fix (remove the root-layout canonical), notFound() for unknown /shop handles, noindex /shop while commerce is off.
- Touch-target pass: 44px on cart steppers, swatches, remove buttons.
- Waitlist referral: share link on the success state, referral column in the schema, first-drop allocation ranked by referrals. The highest-leverage free growth loop available.
- Provision free Upstash so the production rate limiter stops being a no-op.

Phase 2: the funnel gate **BEFORE THE PRODUCTION FLIP**

These block real money. None of them are optional for go-live.

- Shipping-method step in checkout (fetch options, auto-select free, addShippingMethod, show real rate and ETA).
- Razorpay HMAC signature verification before cart.complete; webhook completes abandoned-but-paid carts.
- Server-side overselling guard at add-to-cart and completion.
- Render the size guide / fabric / care / trust blocks on the live PDP (component already exists); age hints on size buttons; image gallery from product.images with the PatchScrubber as slide one, using real patch PNGs instead of placeholder SVGs.
- Mini-cart drawer on add-to-cart with a patch cross-sell strip, plus in-cart "add patches" module. Attach rate is the business model.
- COD pincode serviceability via Shiprocket (autofill city/state, ETA, hide COD where unserviceable). Needs the wallet funded.
- Fix /account/claim (or point at login); wire the existing shipped/delivered email templates to fulfillment events; back-in-stock capture into the waitlist table.
- Sticky mobile add-to-cart bar; gift note field at checkout.
- Legal placeholders filled (entity, address, grievance officer) and the draft banner removed. Hard legal gate under the E-Commerce Rules.

Phase 3: the photography sprint **NEEDS ASH, BIGGEST SINGLE LEVER**

- One phone-camera shoot: 2-3 founder/friend kids in the real prototype tees. Fifteen usable shots: hero on-model, hands-on swap sequence, macro of the velcro panel and a silicone patch edge.
- Cut a 5-8 second muted loop from the existing clip.mp4 (or reshoot): one patch pressed on, peeled off. Place it in the hero card. This is the Crocs Jibbitz move and the highest-converting asset the category has.
- Revive TheRealThing with real photos (the copy is already written in src/content/home.ts).
- Re-render or reshoot the six tee colourways from one template so switching colours does not change the garment's shape.
- Real Instagram with 10+ posts; link it; add a static "From our Instagram" strip.

Phase 4: after launch **POST-FLIP, SEQUENCED BY REVENUE**

- Homepage restructure to the tight model: merge PatchMath into PatchWall, fold PacksShowcase to a 3-up teaser, put the on-model story where the stats were.
- Named-drop calendar: each patch theme becomes a dated drop with its own banner lockup; waitlist gets 24h early access. Plan around late Sep to Diwali, Children's Day (14 Nov), December clearance, June back-to-school.
- Reviews: request email 7 days post-delivery, store in Neon, render on PDP with AggregateRating JSON-LD. Collect consented quotes with photos at pop-ups meanwhile.
- Performance moat: strip "use client" from static sections, cache the region lookup, ISR the PLP/PDP, subset fonts to 2 families, then verify all three Core Web Vitals pass (every reference competitor fails at least one).
- Retention set completion: back-in-stock / next-drop notify first (the waitlist is already the audience), then win-back. Self-serve returns from the order page. Public /track page.
- Trust voice page: publish what a ₹999 tee costs to make and the no-licensed-characters promise, in first person.

What only Ash can unblock

ITEM	FEEDS
Kid photography (one phone shoot) and the swap-loop video	Phase 3, the single biggest conversion lever on the site
Founder photos and one-line bios (names are already known)	Phase 0 Founders section
WhatsApp number for wa.me links	Phase 1 trust channel
Real Instagram handle (create if needed)	Phase 1 footer, Phase 3 social proof
Legal entity name, address, grievance officer, effective dates (with lawyer)	Phase 2 go-live gate
Shiprocket wallet (~₹500) and creds on Railway	Phase 2 COD serviceability and shipping
Next real drop date (or approve undated copy)	Phase 0 banner
cm measurements from the production spec sheet	Phase 1 size guide

Method note: benchmark claims are grounded in direct observation of the named sites and published research (Baymard Institute, WebAIM Million 2025, CrUX field data); competitor Core Web Vitals were verified against field data, not assumed. Audit findings cite specific files and were verified against the live site. Scores are calibrated against "the best clothing websites in the world", not "good for a pre-seed startup".